interact with foreigners and each other in ways that Brahmanical caste prohibitions had formerly prevented. For this reason, Buddhism and Jainism flourished in the cities where new trade relationships were being forged'.[27] In time, partly to accrue religious and social merit, wealthy Buddhist merchants and craft guilds also began donating to Buddhist temples and monasteries.

Royal patronage is best seen not as proof of the monarchs' inherent interest in Buddhism (which they may well have had), but of their interest in legitimizing their own authority by associating with, and investing in, popular religions, and their symbols and institutions. Big religious projects dazzled the commoners. It won the royals religious merit and goodwill. It conferred on them a sort of divine sanction to rule. (Sometimes their self-interested patronizing of many faiths furthered an inclusive and 'secular state' in the Indian sense, much before the term 'secularism' came into being: that is, paying similar attention to all major religions. Take one of Ashoka's own edicts: 'The Beloved of the Gods, [Ashoka], honors all sects and both ascetics and laymen, with gifts and various forms of recognition.') Patronizing Buddhism therefore became a good strategy for the royals after it gained a critical mass of followers, which it likely had by Ashoka's time. Not surprisingly, in late first millennium CE, when support for Buddhism among the laity began drying up, so did the royal patronage (more on this in the next chapter, 'The Vision of Nalanda').

At this point, based on the historical data we have, can we say that ancient India, for well over a millennium, was more of a Buddhist land than a Brahminical one? On one hand, this seems quite plausible. 'Early Buddhism had a substantial following,' writes Romila Thapar. 'For almost a thousand years its presence was almost hegemonic.'[28] On the other hand, we don't have enough data to precisely establish the relative prevalence of Buddhist, Brahminical, Jain, Tantric, animist, polytheist, materialist and other beliefs, or their fusion forms, which was more likely what was practised by the common people.

The fact is that the Chinese monks were far more exposed to an educated urban populace of social, political and religious elites. These were the monks' local informants, and the monks' accounts reflect this bias. This urban demographic—unlike rural or tribal folk who formed the majority of